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The varieties of sonic experience: “Quiet” versus “not-noise” in a Ghanaian harvest festival

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Abstract

Sacred calm engulfs Ghana's town of Nungua every year as the Ga people prepare to celebrate Kplejoo, their annual harvest festival. To honor the presence of deities at this time, the Ga ritual specialists introduce a week-long restriction on drumming and noise-making. The ritual quiet that descends over Nungua defies the conventional categorization of “quietness” as a sonically neutral category. In this context, “quietness” does not translate to the elimination of high frequencies of sound, but rather stands for the perfect sonic habitat for the visiting deities, whose aural sensibilities cannot be subsumed under the “worldly” sonic categories. The article adopts a cross-world acoustemological approach to explore the sonically packed content of “quietness” or “not-noise” in the ritual space of Nungua, placing a special emphasis on ritual songs that are not considered “noisy.” Since the appreciation of “not-noise” is possible only once the deities are introduced into the picture, the work also calls for an increased focus on cross-world sensory transmissions as an important methodological step in the anthropological study of the senses.

KEYWORDS

silence, festival, sound, anthropology of sound, Ghana

Resumen

Una calma sagrada envuelve el pueblo de Nungua en Gana cada año mientras que las personas de GA se preparan para celebrar Kplejoo, su festival anual de la cosecha. Para honrar la presencia de las deidades, los especialistas del ritual Ga introducen una restricción por una semana para tocar tambores y hacer ruido. El silencio del ritual que desciende sobre Nungua desafía la categorización convencional de “tranquilidad” como una categoría sonoramente neutral. En este contexto, “tranquilidad” no se traduce como la eliminación de altas frecuencias de sonido, sino en cambio como el hábitat sónico perfecto para las deidades visitantes, cuyas sensibilidades de aura no pueden ser subsumidas bajo las categorías de sonido “mundanales”. El artículo adopta una aproximación acustomológica a través de los mundos para explorar el contenido empaquetado sonoramente de “tranquilidad” o “no ruido” en el espacio ritual de Nungua, colocando un énfasis especial en canciones rituales que no son consideradas “ruidosas”. Desde que la apreciación de “no ruido” es posible solamente una vez las deidades son

introducidas en escena, el trabajo también llama por un creciente enfoque en las transmisiones sensoriales a través de los mundos como un paso metodológico importante en el estudio antropológico de los sentidos. [*silencio, festival, sonido, antropología del sonido, Ghana*]

In June 2016, I attended the Kplejoo celebration in Nungua, a compact town located on the outskirts of Accra, Ghana. At that point, I had visited Accra on two other occasions as part of my dissertation research on a ritual “ban on drumming” introduced by the local Ga community prior to their harvest celebration. The Ga claim to be the original inhabitants of present-day Accra and the surrounding areas. They possess customary rights over the territory owing to the specifics of the country’s customary land-tenure system that grants special privileges to the “indigenes” of each region. Pronounced and regulated by the *wulmei*—the Ga ritual specialists—the period of quiet is decisive in purifying the community and inaugurating favorable sonic conditions for the Ga deities (*jemawɔji*) who descend to work on the harvest. Once a year, Accra becomes almost unrecognizable as its vivacious sonic profile is enveloped in a silent garb: marketplaces and street vendors no longer blast their dancehall beats, Charismatic churches drag their colossal speakers inside the buildings, and nightclubs close their doors to visitors.

Prior to witnessing harvest ceremonies in Nungua in 2016, I had already attended a number of rites associated with the “ban on drumming” in other Accra-based Ga communities and had experienced the unmistakable sonic metamorphosis that follows the announcement of the ban. On a hot morning in late June, I hopped off a *tro*¹ in the traditional center of Nungua and discovered a soundscape that was utterly different from the state of ritual repose in other Ga neighborhoods. As I strolled down the town’s traditional area dotted with the homes of prominent families, I was swallowed up by Ga ritual music blasting from the little shops and stands selling a variety of local foods and drinks. It was June 28, and we had come to attend the Path Clearing ceremony (Gbɛjɛɛ) celebrated one day after the announcement of the “ban on drumming.” On this day, ritual specialists rise early to prepare the sacred groves for the *jemawɔji*. They clean ritually significant territories from shrubs and weeds, purify them by burning palm incense (*ɣmatsu*), and set up tiny wooden barriers to delineate sacred spaces from the mundane world. Nungua had just entered the state of tranquility when I arrived, yet the participants let out a vigorous chant as they progressed in single file toward the first grove. The hearty performance was punctured by the chimes of two metal bells, known as the *ɣoɣoi* (pl.) in the Ga language. The soundscape was everything but timid; as the crowd accompanied the ritual specialists from one grove to another, they sang stridently, stomped their feet on the ground, and continued to play the *ɣoɣoi*.

The acoustic dimensions of religious practice and ideology have animated the minds of scholars for some time. Unlike the numerous configurations of sound, the state of quiet—or more precisely, the absence of noise—has been a less explored sonic condition even though the two

have always functioned as conjoined twins, giving life and credence to each other’s existence. Taking the effervescence of the soundscape established in the aftermath of the “ban on drumming” in Nungua as a point of reference, my work follows the lead of those anthropologists who question the universalized epistemologies of modernity and rather investigate the culturally determined sensory diversity in constructing knowledge and comprehending social life.

“Noise” and “sound” as subjective entities have received much-deserved attention across disciplines. In this framework, noise is established as a sonic state that is “always ‘colored,’ filtered, limited, and changed by contexts of production and reception” (Novak 2015, 126). Even though the absence of noise as a distinct sonic setup enjoys the same subjective qualities, it remains an underdog of sound studies, with a few, yet notable, exceptions (Ochoa Gautier 2015; Vargas-Cetina 2013). Ochoa Gautier’s (2015, 184) theoretical contribution to the study of silence, as elaborated in her entry for *Keywords in Sound*, deserves a special mention due to its multifaceted assessment of the concept as a denominator of “intensely contrasting experiences.” Fully appreciating the epistemological versatility of silence, however, is only possible once we inspect its distinct, situationally determined significance and meaning. This case-based approach is the key to the larger enterprise of countering the “epistemic coloniality” rooted in the universalization of Western categories of knowledge (Ochoa Gautier 2014). Steven Feld’s notion of “acoustemology” has been decisive in shaping my theoretical approach to sound. Whether contemplating expressive forms suspended between language and music among the Kaluli of Papua New Guinea (Feld [1982] 2012) or tracing threads of cosmopolitanism in the jazz culture of Ghana (Feld 2012), Feld conceptualizes acoustics as a “habit of knowing,” that is, as a way of communicating and producing meaning in the world. Adopting an acoustemological approach, this article outlines the religio-cultural meaning behind the ritual elimination of “noise” in Nungua, focusing specifically on the active, sonically eventful composition of the subsequent acoustic state. Here, I differentiate between “quietness” as an absence from *dioofeemo*, or the “making of quiet,” in the Ga ritual framework, which comes closer to the notion of “not-noise.” “Not-noise” is an active sonic habitat contingent on the preferences of aurally perceptive deities and ancestors, whose sonic designations are also passed down to humans. The salient sound of “not-noise” highlights the idiosyncrasies of our auditory thresholds by incorporating nonhuman entities into the equation and illustrating the wide cultural and circumstantial heterogeneity of sonic categories.

This account is based on the fieldwork I conducted among the Ga between 2014 and 2018 as part of my work on the conflicts surrounding the Ga harvest festival. Although I was primarily based in

Accra proper, I did conduct significant ethnographic work in Nungua, especially during the period of the “ban on drumming,” which consisted of participant observation and interviews with ritual specialists and musicians. When speaking about the contribution of this piece, I need to be clear about my disciplinary standing. Trained as a scholar of religion, I adopt an interdisciplinary lens, which can be best described as a crossover between anthropology, religious studies, sound studies, and history. Investigation of sacred silence offers insight into not only the complex intersection of religion with the sensorium but also the impact of religious acoustics on the culturally determined sensory preferences. Conversations about “not-noise” during the “ban on drumming” in Nungua illustrate that, ultimately, ritual silences, much like ritual sounds, are neither religious nor secular in and of themselves, but rather slip between the categories “in the course of their production, circulation, and consumption” (Jouili and Moors 2014, 983). This “spilling over” of the meanings attached to “not-noise” in the context of cross-world communication has to be investigated further through a deeper plunge into the mundane silence of the Ga. However, I have no doubt that “the interanimation and interarticulation of human and non-human sounds” is a crucial research focus for understanding the multidimensional nature of acoustic orders across cultures (Feld [1982] 2012, xxv).

NUNGUA BLOCKS THE ROAD FOR SOUND

Nungua is situated about ten miles to the east of Accra and boasts a population of almost ninety thousand. Its territory is officially recognized as a constituent of the Ga Traditional Area, which in turn comprises six separate communities. These share language, religion, and cultural traits, but each has its own traditional leadership and religious hierarchy. Whereas Indigenous practices in central Accra gradually merged with rituals introduced by labor migrants, the three Ga communities located outside of Accra—Nungua, Teshie, and Tema—have retained a higher concentration of “the original settlers” and consequently practice older religious customs (Kropp Dakubu 1992; Nii-Dortey 2012). The Ga community in Nungua is deeply convinced that the “tradition” has remained almost intact in the town, and to convey this sense of singularity, they distinguish between the “true Ga” (*Ganyo kroŋ*) and the latecomers (Kilson 1971, 13). The Ga cosmology is composed of four primary cults—Otu, Akɔŋ, Me, and Kple—yet only the latter is considered “national” in character (Field 1937; Nketia 1964), the reason being that the Kple cult represents an amalgamation of practices brought by the earliest Ga settlers and those of the Kpeshi aborigines who were incorporated within the group (Kilson 1971). The word itself means “all-encompassing,” signifying not only the comprehensive nature of the involved practices but also the fact that Kple encapsulates the majority of rites shared by all six Ga communities while all other cults represent a later addition to the core customs.

Kplejoo is an annual celebration classified under a larger cluster of harvest festivals referred to as *Hɔmɔwɔ* and observed with certain variations in the six Ga communities settled in and around Accra. The name of the festival is a compound of two Ga words: *Kple* and *joo*. *Joo* sig-

nifies dancing, or performance in general. Hence, Kplejoo denotes a group of performances dedicated to the Kple deities, who are the most senior in the Ga pantheon, and more broadly, celebrations that are central to the Ga religion. The Ga ritual specialists (*wulomei*) I spoke with affirmed that while Kplejoo has been inculcated into the *Hɔmɔwɔ* festival, it has maintained a more devotional air than *Hɔmɔwɔ* celebrations in the heart of Accra.

The *Hɔmɔwɔ* cluster of festivals commemorates the Ga triumph over a famine that struck the community in a distant past. As one rendition of the story suggests, worn out by unabated attacks from the neighboring Akwamus and weakened from hunger, the Ga warriors decided to use cunning to defeat the enemy. The chief of Haatso told me the tale of victory with much laughter and humor:

They decided to use corn to prepare *kpoikpoi* [a traditional ritual meal of ground millet with palm nut soup now used for *Hɔmɔwɔ*] and some soup and lay it on the side of the road as they hid in the bush. When the Akwamu people came, they thought that the Ga had run away and left the delicious food behind. So, they ate the meal and their stomachs started running. They became weak and that gave the Ga the opportunity to overcome them.²

Historians date the period of the Ga–Akwamu antagonism to between 1660 and 1730 (Odotei 1991; Parker 2000). This was the time when interaction between the two groups assumed the form of wars in which the Ga usually remained defeated.

An equally popular account of the genesis of *Hɔmɔwɔ* dates the festival to the time when the Ga forefathers settled in Ayawaso, the former Ga capital located twenty-four miles north of Accra. It should be noted that this occurrence also coincides with the Ga–Akwamu antagonism mentioned above, so *Hɔmɔwɔ* cluster of festivals must have emerged somewhere in the late seventeenth to early eighteenth century. The story goes that the settlers were hit by a terrible famine, so the *wulomei* entered a period of silence to plead with the supreme deity, Ataa-Naa Nyɔŋmɔ, to grant them an abundant harvest. “Lo and behold, they had a lot of food,” is how the chief of Ofankor related the events as we spoke in 2018. “The corn that they planted yielded a lot and they had a bumper harvest. So, they realized that this is a very good tradition, and every year we observe the silence so that we can talk to our maker, god almighty, to bless the people of the Ga state.”³ It is no coincidence that the name of the festival, *Hɔmɔwɔ*, literally translates to “hooting at hunger,” commemorating the time when the Ga vanquished the adversary.

Hɔmɔwɔ is the occasion when all individuals related to the six Ga communities, even those who currently live in other regions, are obliged to return to their ancestral homes to bolster kinship ties with the living and deceased members of their families (Odotei 2002; Omaboe 2011). As the kinfolk share a ceremonial meal of *kpoikpoi*, they give thanks to their deities and ancestors for another year of peace and plentiful harvest (Kilson 2013). Despite their “national” character, harvest festivals are celebrated with certain variations in the six Ga

communities and span distinct time frames. The most distinguishing feature of Kplejoo in Nungua is the brevity of the period of silence. Whereas the “ban on drumming” lasts for four weeks elsewhere, it only spans one week in Nungua. Moreover, in Nungua and its adjacent town Tema, the feast gradually merged with the older Kple observances and is referred to as Kplejoo rather than Hɔmɔwɔ (Ammah 2016, 341; Field 1937, 5, 89).

Kplejoo in Nungua is an elaborate affair; it consists of various preparatory rituals that lead to a climactic possession ceremony. While individual rites are interesting on their own terms, this article focuses on the one-week period of “not-noise” that follows the ceremony of Gbɛmlilaa.⁴ The title of the ceremony translates as “closing the road,” since it symbolically marks the period when death, noise, and agitation are confined outside of the town’s borders, so that humans can commune with the deities who are stopping over in the world of the living to work on the harvest. Since Kple deities are the oldest and, hence, the most senior among the four Ga cults, their advent in the world of the living is considered a consequential event to behold. Prior to the announcement of the ban, *anɛgle* drums⁵ summon Nungua’s ninety gods, and once they go silent, the community enters the one-week sonic abstinence (Nii-Dortey 2012, 80–81; E. A. B. 1981, 48).

There are several explanations as to why absence of noise is crucial at this time. For one, sound plays a key role in the reciprocal relationship between human and suprahuman worlds. Being strongly attuned to sonic signals in the terrestrial realm, the *jemawɔji* and ancestors, who in everyday speech are known simply as *mɔmɔi* or spirits, can make themselves physically present via sonic paths (Friedson 2009).⁶ Special forms of music, when performed in the correct setting, can sacralize space and time and promote a cross-world dialogue (Roseman and Peek 1994). To facilitate a continuous companionship of their deities, the devotees have rendered musical experience the cornerstone of ritual life. In 2016, when Nungua residents were preparing for Kplejoo, I had an extensive discussion with the chief drummer of the community regarding the communicative potential of music. Sitting outside of his small compound, tucked away in the labyrinth of winding passages in Nungua’s old town, Nii Afotey detailed the cross-world synergy that transpires during special rites.

When we play and play, we “invoke” [in Eng.] the spirits and they “enter” [*bote*] human beings. We “pull” the spirits [*gbala*].⁷

Be that as it may, the “ban on drumming” is not the time for merrymaking and haphazard intraworld interactions; after all, aiding the growth of fine crops requires heightened concentration and significant labor on the part of the deities. For this reason, no deity should be “pulled away” from the harvest lest it turns out scarce. Working themselves to the bone to ensure a bumper year for the community, the last thing the *mɔmɔi* want is noise. While they come with blessings, there is always the fear of them going back if they find the human world in a sonic disarray. A Ga traditionalist⁸ compared the situation to a father coming home after work and finding the place noisy: “It does not allow for him to concentrate, so he will not be happy.”⁹ The worry that the *jemawɔji*

and *mɔmɔi* might get distracted is so powerful that in the past, Ga families even refrained from frying fish to prevent vexing the celestial visitors by accidental coughing.¹⁰ The fact that members of a fishing community would be willing to prepare their meals on the outskirts of the town for the duration of the ban speaks to the gravity of the endeavor. A more scientific rendering of the ban maintains that the planted millet refuses to grow in sonically jarring conditions and, consequently, the shortage of harvest is directly proportional to the dearth of divine blessings. Last, but not least, absence of “noise” is instrumental in generating a state of purity and reflection that can ensure the highest possible quality of contact with the *jemawɔji* (E. A. B. 1981, 43).

A strong alliance with the deities is especially critical for the ritual specialists who are liable for seeking divine guidance for the community. In the words of the Ga scholar Philip Laryea (2011, 113), “the main work of the *wulɔmɛi* is that the *jemawɔji* narrate to them their goals and desires to be translated to the townspeople so that they pray for the town.” Indeed, after one week of prayer, the *wulɔmɛi* tell their people about the directions dispensed by the deities on how to live next year.¹¹ The Gbɛmlilaa ceremony signals the *wulɔmɛi* to embark on intensive prayer in their shrines (*gbaatsui*) to garner blessings from Ataa-Naa Nyɔɔmɔ and the *jemawɔji*. The all-consuming meditation that transpires during the period demands substantial energy from the ritual specialists and all distractions need to be avoided. The deputy chief *wulɔmɔ* of Nungua described the process in the following way: “Gbɛmlilaa is good for the whole town because when we pray, we don’t pray for ourselves only, we pray for the whole town, and the Ga-Dangme people, or the whole country of Ghana, or even the whole world. If there is a war in any part of the world, we pray so that it ends.”¹²

A Christian-influenced reading of the process takes the deities out of the equation and compares the practice to Lent. According to this interpretation, humans need a period of introspection in anticipation of major spiritual events; while Christians and Muslims change their food consumption, the Ga temper their sonic intake, entering a period of “sonic fast” in order to cleanse their minds and souls.¹³ My Christian Ga friends likened the quiet during the festival to a “clear vision” in prayer and supplication, or even “the consciousness of life itself.” The suffusion of Ghana’s public discourse with Christian phraseology, symbolism, and imagery also meant that some *wulɔmɛi* are gradually starting to conceive the absence of noise as decisive for a personal communication with “the creator.” In most cases, we find that the Ga community members accept a combination of the mentioned expositions for the absence of noise. The Nai *Wulɔmɔ* of Jamestown, one of the highest-ranking *wulɔmɛi* of the Ga community, for instance, presented a vision of the “ban on drumming” that emphasized self-denial and cleansing alongside the importance of curbing noise to allow the deities to pass information to ritual specialists.¹⁴

THE SOUND OF SILENCE

In the Kple music, an assortment of three drums (*tele*, *anɛgle*, and *awire*) and two *ɲoɲoi* form the corpus of ritual performance. As the most “gregarious” instrument, the drum is the primary mediator between

human and nonhuman worlds (Blacking 1973; Nketia 1974; Rattray 1923). The act of “pulling” the spirits down can only be performed with the drum; the Ga word being used here is *gbala*, literally to “drag,” “draw out,” or “pull.” Each *jemawɔɲ* has its own song, which incites it to mount the priest medium who is dedicated to its shrine. If drummers miss a beat, the *jemawɔɲ* will immediately react by means of its devoted medium. While all ritual drums possess the potential to transmit cues to the suprahuman realm, playing the three drums in unison can “bring” (*ba*) the celestial beings faster. At ritual dances I attended in various Ga townships, I often witnessed the *jemawɔɲ* responding to the sound of the instruments through their female priest mediums (*wɔyei*). In a conversation that took place in 2017, a Ga chief from the Asere clan described this communion between the deities and ritual music:

You know the snakes, when you play music they come to where the music is being played. Snakes, they like music, they will come. Music also attracts the deities, they also come. Except that we haven't got the eyes to identify them, but there are those who see and they tell us.... So, when you play music that attracts them, they will come, because they also want to listen, they also want to be part of the joy making.¹⁵

In all likelihood, Nii Amon was referring to the practice of snake charming in South Asia and North Africa. The visual stereotype of a charmer crouching in front of a basket with a coiling cobra has long entranced human minds due to its association with magic (Racy 2016). Initially believed to be mesmerized by music, now we know that snakes, in fact, follow the *pungi* that the charmer holds. Nonetheless, the underlying metaphor is more than apparent—the deities in the Ga cosmology are enthralled by human music and venture out of their abode to “listen” to the alluring tunes. However, only the *wulomei* “have the eyes” to discern their presence. The quote also intimates that the *jemawɔɲ* are captivated by ritual music because it is a profoundly positive experience that enables them to join humans in their merriment.

Owing to their capacity to charm the deities, drums hold a special place in the Ga pantheon. I have heard musicians suggest that individual drums represent various *jemawɔɲ*. It is assumed, for instance, that the largest of the three drums is called *oboade* (The Creator) because it epitomizes the voice of the supreme god, Ataa-Naa Nyɔɲmɔ (Nii-Dortey 2012, 94). The chief drummer of Nungua relayed that, for him, the primary manifestation of the drum's sacredness is the feeling you experience when you play it: “you become like a feather, very, very light. They make you play. That's why I can assure you they are also deities.”¹⁶ Yet another indication of the drum's superior ranking is the way it is reverentially handled. Ritual drums are among those sacred objects that are kept in the male-only domain of the household (*hiiamli*) to avoid female contamination (Hampton 1982, 76). Even male drummers, who have been selected by the *jemawɔɲ* to play their music, have to become clean (*tse*) before they can touch the instruments (E. A. B. 1981, 48). The drums cannot be brought outside without first undergoing special customs; they need to be “bathed” in a mixture of white and black chalk and eggs and dressed in medicinal leaves.¹⁷ Numo Osuali Boketey,

the deputy chief *wulomɔ* of Nungua, told me that in case he needs to approach the drums, he rubs himself with Florida water and avoids transgressing any ritual taboos to ward off spiritual contamination.

In the solemn period leading up to the harvest celebration, the Ga take special care not to confuse or irritate their deities with a multitude of aural signals. Since the drum “awakens” the *jemawɔɲ*, it makes sense that prohibition on drumming has been especially important, followed by prohibitions on clapping, whistling, and sizzling, sounds the deities also find unacceptable due to their association with feasting and merriment. With rapid amplification of sonic signals in the past decades, combined with the acoustic incursion of Pentecostal/Charismatic Christian denominations, as will be discussed in the next section, the ritual sonic prohibition has gradually expanded to include virtually all forms of noise making in the majority of Ga towns. However, both written sources and oral history intimate that even prior to the revised regulations, Ga communities entered a state of peaceful contemplation that required active prayer, rest from physical creation, and little spiritual or acoustic agitation. All forms of music were off-limits during this time.

For the sake of clarity, I must note that the Ga distinguish between “worship” and “worldly” songs. In the Kple ritual context, the former are known as either Kple *lalai* (Kple songs) or *jamo lalai* (worship songs) and are performed with the help of drums and metal bells. Since Kple songs were revealed by the *jemawɔɲ*, the prerequisite for their sacred quality is their immutability (Kilson 1971; Nii-Dortey 2012; Nketia 1964). This constraint on modification is the reason why the majority of Kple songs have sections in the original Obutu language¹⁸ of the Kpeshi aborigines whose practices were adopted by the Ga settlers (Field 1937; Kropp Dakubu 1972, 1992). These sections are largely unintelligible for the contemporary Ga. On the other hand, “songs of the world” (*jeɲ lalai*) are played for recreational purposes, merrymaking, and entertainment both within and outside the festival context. As a common form of creative self-expression, these songs are composed by ordinary men and women—members of carnival bands, popular music troupes, and warrior associations (*asafoi*). Their mundane origin and nonritualized performance renders *jeɲ lalai* impotent in summoning the *jemawɔɲ*, yet they can nonetheless serve as a nuisance for them. As such, both the Kple music and the recreational *jeɲ lalai* are prohibited during the “ban on drumming.”

What renders Nungua and its adjacent town Teshie unconventional is that their period of “quiet-making” accommodates an additional variation of Kple music that is played without drums and is not classified as “noise.” Nii Afotey, the chief drummer of Nungua was the first to point out the distinction: “with the *kusum* [custom] we don't play drums; that is why you can play *kusum* music during the ban on drumming.” Known as *kusum lalai* (customary songs) in the colloquial, this variety of Kple music is called “Obene” in the scholarly discourse (Nii-Dortey 2012; Nketia 1958, 1988). Obene music is accompanied by two bells (*ɲoɲoi*), male chanting, and what Kwabena Nketia (1988) refers to as “the ground-stamping dance.” Unlike the drum-centered variety of the Kple music, which is reserved for strictly ritualized and often confidential ceremonies, *kusum lalai* routinely involve public performances and can also be played as recordings at home or outside in the course of the “ban on drumming” (Nii-Dortey 2012, 150).

While in other Ga towns, the *jemawɔji* do not tolerate any noise, in Nungua, they are perfectly content if *kusum lalai* are performed or played via recordings. It follows, then, that this form of music comfortably fits in the category of “not-noise” for both terrestrial and celestial residents of Nungua. Most importantly, the volume of *kusum lalai* can be as high as the performers wish, or if they are played via recordings, as loud as the technology allows. When I asked a Ga elder why *kusum lalai* were tolerated during the ban and not considered noisy, he responded without hesitation: “That one is custom. Those are festivity songs, it is not like somebody is making noise.”¹⁹ I posed a similar question to a ritual specialist in Nungua, and he explained that while the deities might not generally like noise at the time designated for introspection, they thoroughly enjoy *kusum lalai* since it is their music.²⁰ Besides, these songs boost the *jemawɔji*’s strength and focus. In other words, it is a common perception in Nungua that the town succeeds in establishing “quiet” (*dioo/kpoo*) following the Gbɛmlilaa custom, since neither deities nor humans find *kusum lalai* “noisy.”

The distinction between “noise” and “not-noise” in the Nungua ritual framework ultimately comes down to sounds that generate a sense of peacefulness and sounds that agitate. The volume, as measured in decibels, is trivial in the appraisal. In the words of Nii Afotey, “anything that would make you startled [*heleshi*] is not allowed. But you are free to sing.” The singing pertains to *kusum lalai* and not to popular songs since worldly noises “startle” both the *jemawɔji* and the human psyche. In a nutshell, there is a reciprocal relationship between our emotional condition and the way we perceive and label sounds. A song recorded by Allan P. Merriam (1982, 347) among the Bala of the Republic of Congo clearly communicates this emotional dimension of our sonic worlds:

When you are content, you sing; when you are angry you make noise.

When one shouts, he is not thinking; when he sings, he is thinking.

A song is tranquil; a noise is not.

When one shouts, his voice is forced; when he sings, it is not.

There are, thus, two major explanations as to why the *kusum lalai* are not classified as noise by the residents of Nungua and, consequently, are permitted during the “ban on drumming.” For one, this type of music does not require drums, the key implement of cross-world socialization in the Ga cosmology. The omission of drums means that the deities can peacefully continue working on their tasks while enjoying the *kusum lalai*. This brings me to the second point: rather than distracting, the *kusum lalai* are pleasing to the celestial aural tastes, since they were gifted to humans by the *jemawɔji* themselves. Owing to their linguistic and melodious content, the *kusum lalai* have a calming effect on both the deities and humans, and this sentiment is most compatible with the reverential aura of the “ban on drumming.” By contrast, “noisy” sounds and earthly songs that often use foul language or jarring tonalities unhinge the emotional state of the human and superhuman agents.

The aurally dynamic “quietness” that settles over Nungua during the “ban on drumming” is yet another illustration of the multiplicity

of “silences” we find in distinct cultural and social contexts. “Our notions of peaceful silence,” write Michael Bull and Les Back (2003, 10), “are mediated through culture.” It is hardly unthinkable, then, that the chirping of birds so soothing to Jean Jacques Rousseau on his walks in the countryside would seem unbearable to Gustav Mahler as he wrote his Symphony No. 3 (Bull and Back 2003). Even so, “not-noise” or “quietness” in Nungua is sonically rowdy enough to merit attention. In the Euro-American linguistic and conceptual framework, “noise” and “sound” are largely active categories. They are active since they are believed to require effort, action, or movement, broadly defined. Dictionary definitions of “quiet” as an aural state, on the other hand, generally point to the absence of sound, and especially the absence of “noise” or “uproar.” In fact, both “quiet” and “silence” could involve some level of sound, but usually sound that is not disturbing. The roots of the English word “quiet” are traced back to the Old French *quiete*, which signifies “rest, repose, tranquility,” and the Latin *quies*, meaning “a lying still, rest, repose” and lastly, “inactivity.”²¹ Thus, “quiet,” much like “silence,”²² is linguistically a relatively neutral sonic setting associated with inaction, as opposed to “loud,” “cacophonous,” and “harmonious” sonic experiences that require effort to be produced. The notion of inactivity implicit in this definition is clearly stretched to its limit in the period of the “ban on drumming” in Nungua. However, it continues to make sense once we holistically link this sensory experience with other structures of meaning and become familiar with “modes and codes of sound communication” common to all involved parties, especially the deities (Feld 1996, 100).

The two words customarily used in reference to the sonic condition that ensues after the “ban on drumming” are *kpoofeemɔ* and *dioofeemɔ*, both of which can be literally translated as “the making of quiet/silence.” The Ga verb *fee* that denotes the act of “quiet-” or “silence-making” is translated as “to do, perform, make” or “to act upon, perform an act on.” These verb-nouns are revealing since they imply that “silence” requires active making rather than simply unmaking of “sound” or “noise,” which would leave us with the absence of sonic signals. Since presence and activity are vital to *dioofeemɔ*, I find it more accurate to refer to the sonic environment that ensues after the “ban on drumming” as “not-noise” rather than “quiet” or “silence,” which inadvertently conjure sonic vacancy. This emphasis on presence rather than absence is consistent with Dominique Zahan’s (1979, 117) assessment of “silence” among the Bamana, which he describes as “not an absence, still less a lack, but a present reality.” It is possible that the terms *kpoofeemɔ* and *dioofeemɔ* refer to the effort put into enforcing a period of silence in a generally “noisy” environment. However, I suspect that they tell us more, namely that the absence of noise in the Ga ritual context does not actually mean elimination of high frequencies of sound but rather the creation of “not-noise”—the perfect sonic habitat for the visiting deities.

In Feld’s “acoustemology” of Kaluli birds, the main function of examining the invisible domain is to untangle the meaning of birds beyond what is visible, without being limited to specific areas of knowledge. “Instead of trying to separate zoology and myth as distinct and neatly bounded modes of observation and deduction,” Feld ([1982] 2012, 45) writes, “I needed to see just how Kaluli packaged them together in a

mutually supportive way, based on certain fundamental premises of the world." The instinct to delve into cosmological orders that structure the physically manifested world is innate to my methodology, as I've been trained in the study of religion. That is why I find the compounding of the multilayered meanings of "myths, seasons, colors, gender, taboos, curses, spells, time, space, and naming" in Feld's ([1982] 2012, 83) work so inspiring. What differentiates my approach, however, is the methodological interest in bringing the invisible and visible worlds together in order to expand our understanding of how sounds are systematized and experienced. Being acquainted with the sonic habits of suprahuman beings within their own sociocultural contexts introduces another layer of meaning to the way soundscapes are perceived, described, labeled, and regulated.

FROM DRUMMING TO NOISE MAKING

When attaching culturally specific sacred layers to sensory categories, we need to be careful not to fall into the narrative of sensory enchantment, which will ultimately lead us to structuralist divisions across geographic, political, or cultural lines. Instead, it is best to dwell on the versatility of sensory concepts and experiences, understanding that their essence is situational rather than static. The Ga, just like others, ascribe more than one meaning to their sonic classifications, which in turn emanate from sociocultural negotiations (Sykes 2015). Thus, the sonically vivid "quiet" so deeply appreciated by the deities and humans of Nungua can swiftly become disenchanted when conferring with an out-group, passing into a more rigid form of "quiet" as "absence of sound."

Intergroup sound-regulation patterns are usually dictated by the prevalent aural taxonomies contingent on the sonic predilections of communities that wield power. Official or unofficial campaigns designed to suppress "noise"—or more accurately, the allegedly inferior individuals or groups that produce it—are the focus of several histories of sound set in Europe and the United States across periods that, to varying degrees, constitute the dawn of the modern era (B. Smith 1999, 2003; M. Smith 2001). Accounts of *fin de siècle* noise-abatement campaigns are particularly telling of the ideological shifts that juxtaposed middle-class sensibilities of progress and moral discipline against the "vulgar" sonic profiles of the working classes or immigrants (Bijsterveld 2008; Payer 2007; Thompson 2002). In addition to allowing a group to simply express its identity and demarcate its domain of influence (Oosterbaan 2009; Rasmussen 2017), inter- and intragroup acoustic articulations have the capacity to interject marginal subjects into the dominant narrative, allowing their censored discourses to come to the fore—think, for example, of the defiant sonic profile of rap music as a force of resistance (Reynolds 2007; Rose 1994). It follows that "silence"—signifying both voicelessness and elimination of the adversary's "noise"—can also be a reaction to power (Attali 1985; Ochoa Gautier 2015).

In the case of the Ga religion, Pentecostal/Charismatic Christianity has epitomized the "Other" since the late 1980s, when the latter monopolized Ghana's religious scene, marking its undeniable presence via sound waves emanating from every nook and cranny of the urban

landscape. To demonstrate authority in the multireligious marketplace of Ghana, Pentecostal/Charismatic Christians did not refrain from violating the sacred period of silence preceding the Ga harvest festival. The delinquency can be attributed to two key factors. From the start, the Pentecostal/Charismatic movement professed to be the antithesis of "tradition" and the harbinger of "modernity." The branding of "culture" as a localizing force that forestalled Ghana's progress rendered the transgression of the Ga ritual ban an act of protest. Apart from that, the violation cannot be divorced from the indispensable place of music in Pentecostal/Charismatic worship. This appetite for musicality is commonly framed as a divine command. During my fieldwork, pastors would routinely urge us to "shout for joy to the Lord" (Psalm 98:4), to "praise him with the sounding of the trumpet" (Psalm 150:1–6), and to "sing to the Lord a new song" (Psalm 96:1–2). To put it in Charles Hirschkind's (2006) words, the Pentecostal/Charismatic sensorium is "ethically responsive" to the acoustic impact of sacred "noise." "Making noise" for God is a trusted method of purging sinfulness and contamination.

As an implement of spiritual advancement, "noise" is simultaneously redefined in terms of a sought-after auditory experience that can ensure intimacy with the divine. When I pressed a member of the Evangel Church International to explain the appeal of the concept, he spoke of a different type of "noise"—a noise that "makes sense":

When the God says, "make a joyful noise," the noise should be with meaning. There is stupid noise, which does not make sense, but there is some noise, which makes sense. The joyful noise should come from within to without, from inside of you.²³

The Pentecostal/Charismatic differentiation between "meaningful" and "meaningless" noise resonates with the distinction made by the Ga between songs that register as "noise" and those that are "not-noise." However, while Pentecostal/Charismatics clearly favor the term "noise" to describe pleasant musical experiences, the Ga engage in "quiet-making" by eliminating "noise" and sanctioning meaningful sounds that are "not-noise."

Regrettably, their mutual appreciation of "meaningful" sound did not aid the two sides in escaping confrontations in the late 1990s when the refusal of Pentecostal/Charismatic congregations to take the edge off their sonically prominent worship reached its apparent zenith. The tensions can hardly be divorced from the sociocultural shifts emblematic of the period. Heightened public presence of Pentecostal/Charismatic churches aided by the liberalization of media, rapid inflow of labor migrants who joined the new churches, and the impudent treatment of the Ga traditional authorities and practices on the part of Pentecostal/Charismatic pastors led to their gradual singling out as the primary culprits behind the marginalization of the Ga community (Asamoah-Gyadu 2005; Asante 2011).

To avoid being crushed by the competition, the Ga were quick to retaliate with a taste of their own sonic medicine. In addition to engaging in legal and discursive battles over the violation of the customary law that mandates conservation of "traditional practices," they pushed

back by fortifying the contours of their authority via the “seizure of soundscape” (Oosterbaan 2009) and the reworking of the “quiet” they sought to establish on their territories (Arthur 2018; De Witte 2008; Goshadze 2019). The most illustrious indication of this adjustment in the print media was the gradual adaptation of the associated terminology. Reports on the harvest festival in the *Daily Graphic*, the most widely read public newspaper in the country, slowly altered the term for the Ga ritual noise constraint from “ban on drumming” to “ban on drumming and noise making.” Thus, the previous conception of “noise” in the Ga ritual context, with drumming, clapping, and whistling as its primary components, was substituted with a broader, more secular category comprising other sources of noise production. This semiotic shift from a clear-cut set of sounds to the overall noise gave the Ga more freedom to target Christian churches as offenders.

The “ban on drumming” became a potent tool because it did not necessitate entering into a sonic competition with Pentecostal/Charismatic congregations by overshadowing their sounds. To be fair, the Ga community would stand no chance against the technologically “amplified piety” of the wealthier born-again congregations (Gerety 2017). Instead, they weaponized “quiet-making” via targeted elimination of the threatening sonic presence. Although the content of the established “quiet” in Nungua has not changed, elimination of all forms of “noise” became the discursive focus of the public statements made by the Ga community leaders in the process of conflict resolution. They argued that transgression of the ban could have pernicious effects not only for the Ga but also for the perpetrators who would be, sooner or later, punished by the *jemawɔji* for their irreverence. Ultimately, the Ga counteraction proved to be fruitful, since the state introduced regulatory measures in defense of the customary practices, and sonic violations have since become an oddity.

Such strategic use of the “ban on drumming” to counter the “noise” of the adversary draws attention to the multilayered meaning and function of sonic categories in the Ga cultural context. For one, we can clearly discern the melodic saturation of the Ga “not-noise,” which stands out from the more familiar quietness as an absence of noise. Simultaneously, however, modifications introduced to the “sonic fast” vis-à-vis the Pentecostal/Charismatic churches—which continue to be in harmony with the Ga cosmology—point to the overall suppleness and multifunctionality of sensory epistemologies and their strategic responsiveness to hostile socio-political circumstances.

CROSS-WORLD ACOUSTEMOLOGY

Investigation of the senses has undergone significant shifts in the past decades. Most importantly, the modernist narrative of the ascendancy of sight over other senses has proved to be simplistic at best, and grossly disruptive at worst, due to its association with the linear evolutionary schema so central to the colonial enterprise. A comparative perspective popularized in the 1960s by Walter Ong (1967) and Marshall McLuhan (1962) introduced a modification to the model, opting for sensory differentiation rather than hierarchization. In this rendering, Western ocularcentrism was simply juxtaposed

against the orality of non-Western peoples. Still, cultural demarcations persevered; whether heightened aurality was interpreted as a sign of intellectual limitation or spiritual liberation, the two worlds—one of rationality and progress, and the other of sensuality and timelessness, remained irreconcilable (Schmidt 2000). As scholarly focus on the ear and hearing expands in its scope and intensity, the goal is to forgo structuralist tendencies and unveil the ubiquitous world of aurality with its culturally distinct epistemological meanings and implications (Ochoa Gautier 2014).

The most notable inquiries into sound for the past decades share an aspiration to denaturalize Western standards and to focus instead on the multifaceted and circumstantial nature of the sensory domain. In anthropology, David Howes (1991, 2005) and Constance Classen (1993, 1997) are notable for reassessing the interplay of the senses within the given cultural framework as socially and historically constituted (see also Porcello et al. 2010). Building on this methodological foundation, rigorous incursions into the varieties of acoustic perception come from anthropologists and sound studies scholars who press their fieldwork into the service of rethinking sensory hierarchies and dichotomies that permeate academic and popular discourse. To this end, historians have also actively questioned the established sensory paradigms by “un-airing” sounds of the past and the alternative sensorial histories that harbor them (Picker 2003; B. Smith 2003; Yablon 2007). These pursuits clearly reveal a historically sustained preoccupation with sound as a measure of sociocultural meaning.

Mindful of the developments in the study of the senses, in this article, I have ventured to examine the meaning of sound or absence thereof in the ritual context of Nungua.²⁴ My contribution to the anthropological study of sound is double layered and includes disciplinary and conceptual dimensions. First off, as a scholar of religion, I advocate for pointing our ears in the direction of nonhuman entities who, to varying degrees, partake in modeling human soundscapes. Do these actors communicate acoustically? To what degree and in which areas do their actions and inclinations inform the sonic profiles of humans? While my primary focus of inquiry is the ritual framework of Nungua, as I demonstrate in the last section, sonic categories dictated by nonhuman entities within ritual contexts also spill into mundane domains, modified according to the necessities of human actors. Ultimately, I suggest that increased attention to cross-world sonic transmissions adds a new layer to the anthropological study of the senses and could be potentially employed beyond the sonic domain.

The subjective nature of our senses conditions us to experience and interpret sonic signals that are reasonable to be anticipated within the cultural context where we reside. Hence, adopting an acoustemological approach that is mindful of the cross-world sonic exchange has allowed me to identify a unique form of “quietness” in the framework of the Ga festival, contributing to the variety of culturally specific conceptions of silences across geographic and social contexts. Despite significant advancements in the study of sound, discursive polarity typical of the previous model endures in the scholarly fascination with the acoustic complexity and transcendence of non-Western cultures (Schmidt 2003). Since I examine “quietness” or “not-noise” through

non-Western, culturally specific understandings, I want to distance myself from the generalized claims regarding the exceptionality of the African sensory order. Instead, I argue that the active, sonically packed content of “quietness” in the framework of the Ga harvest festival contributes to the appreciation of the multifaceted, situational character of sensory experiences that are ever-present.

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NOTES

- ¹ A privately owned mini bus used for public transportation all over Ghana.
- ² Nii Amarsoglah IV, Interview, July 21, 2016.
- ³ Nii Korteyboi II, Interview, February 14, 2018.
- ⁴ For detailed description of major ceremonies in Kplejoo festival in Nungwa, see Nii-Dortey (2012), E.A.B. (1981), and Nketia (1988).
- ⁵ One of the three ritual drums used in Kple rites.
- ⁶ The difference between the deities and the ancestors is not easy to pin down. Ancestors, just like the *jemawɔji*, reveal themselves through dreams and possessions; both beings are also actively involved in the affairs of mortals (Hampton 1982). Both *jemawɔji* and ancestors can be conjured up with the help of libations, or can manifest as ghosts and in dreams (Kilson 1968, 907).
- ⁷ Nii Afotey, Interview, June 27, 2016.
- ⁸ This term is used both by insiders and outsiders to refer to the followers of the Ga religion.
- ⁹ Nii Amarsoglah IV, Interview, July 21, 2016.
- ¹⁰ Abraham Klu Sowah, Interview, August 2, 2016.
- ¹¹ Nii Afotey, Interview, June 27, 2016.
- ¹² Numo Osuali Boketey, Interview, March 8, 2018.
- ¹³ Daniel Lankai Lawson, Interview, September 15, 2017.
- ¹⁴ Numo Akwaa Mensah III, Interview, November 8, 2017.
- ¹⁵ Nii Amon Kotei II, Interview, October 17, 2017.
- ¹⁶ Nii Afotey, Interview, June 27, 2016.
- ¹⁷ Numo Osuali Boketey, Interview, March 8, 2018.
- ¹⁸ A dialect of the Guan language, which belongs to the Niger-Congo language family.
- ¹⁹ Nii Odotei-Adjei, Interview, November 7, 2017.
- ²⁰ Numo Osuali Boketey, Interview, March 8, 2018.
- ²¹ See <https://www.etymonline.com/word/quiet>.
- ²² Etymologically, the word “silence” derives from the Gothic verb *anasilan* (the wind dying down) and the Latin *desinere* (stop).
- ²³ Ekow Takyi-Dadzie, Interview, October 6, 2017.
- ²⁴ For those interested in the senses more broadly, a brilliant investigation of the socio-historically conditioned sensorium in the context of Ghana can be found in Kathryn Geurts's *Culture and the Senses* (2002). Via her thorough semiotic investigation, Geurts details the Anlo-Ewe bodily ways of knowing that converge around the sense of balance.

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